



Guyana



On the northeast coast of South America, Guyana is the continent's only English-speaking country. Independent since 1966, it has close ties with the anglophone Caribbean.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly artificial coast, reclaimed by dikes and dams from swamps and tidal marshes. Forests cover 85% of the interior, rising to savanna uplands and mountains.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Coast cooled by sea breezes. Lowlands are hot, wet, and humid. Highlands are a little cooler.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Guyana is a complex multiracial society. Tension exists between the Afro-Guyanese, descended from slaves, and the Indo-Guyanese, descendants of laborers brought over after slavery was abolished. Politics is highly polarized around this split and has often spilled over into violence on the streets. Amerindian subsistence farmers are the poorest people in society and have little representation.



THE ECONOMY

Diverse exports: gold, sugar, fish, bauxite, rice, timber, diamonds. Debt relief granted. Narcotics transit zone.



INSIGHT: *Guyana means "land of many waters," reflecting its dense network of rivers*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Cooperative Republic of Guyana

DATE OF FORMATION: 1966

CAPITAL: Georgetown

POPULATION: 762,500

TOTAL AREA: 83,000 sq. miles

(214,970 sq. km)

DENSITY: 10 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Creole, Hindi, English*

RELIGIONS: Christian 57%, Hindu 33%, Muslim 9%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: East Indian 43%, Black African 30%, other 18%, Amerindian 9%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Guyanese dollar = 100 cents